



over 60 per cent for the last five seasons. The table-toppers at the mid-season interval — Karnataka, Bengal, Vidarbha, and Mumbai — have played out nine draws so far. Last season, the group winners had a cumulative total of nine draws after the final round. Yet, the relatively consistent conditions have bridged the gulf in skill between the traditional heavyweights and the rest, making this Ranji Trophy more evenly contested.

Jammu & Kashmir's (J&K) first win over seven-time champion Delhi has been the highlight of the season. The Paras Dogra-led side sits second in Group D with 20 points, and could have been top if not for its agonising 35-run reverse against Mumbai. J&K's success has rested on the strength of its pace unit, led by Auqib Nabi, who has 29 wickets in five games at an average of 13.67.

Similarly, Services, Jharkhand, and Haryana — sides devoid of international stars — have punched above their weight and are in contention for making the knockouts.

On the other hand, Tamil Nadu finds itself languishing in the bottom half of its group.

The smaller units have proved stiff opponents for the bigger sides, even in instances where it might not be evident in terms of points won.

Nagaland, which played in the Plate Group last season, nearly eked out a first-innings lead against Tamil Nadu courtesy of a century from Imliwati Lemtur.

Nagaland's fortunes this season pose a question for the Plate Group and its members. The side nearly pulled off a heist against a domestic giant but also fell to three innings defeats. Isolated from the tournament, Plate sides might gain better exposure from facing top-drawer teams in a couple of rounds every season.

However, this is not the only predicament the Ranji Trophy is confronted with. Multiple captains and head coaches have raised their displeasure with the mid-season interval, which holds the potential of running down their team's

Pitch paradox: India head coach Gautam Gambhir has repeatedly stressed the importance of domestic cricket, but flatter Ranji pitches this season have raised questions about how closely conditions mirror Test demands. AP

momentum accumulated through five rounds.

There are, however, voices in favour of the break. Mumbai captain Shardul Thakur, who was among the first few cricketers to raise questions over the packed scheduling of the Ranji Trophy, expressed his satisfaction over the new system, while Siddhesh Lad, too, believes that, keeping the larger interest in mind, this is the right move.

"I feel this is the right thing to do. Obviously, as a guy who is in form, it could break my momentum. But it is also about workload. In the last five games, we have fielded for 100–150 overs, and then batted, and as our coach Omkar Salvi says, the Ranji Trophy is like a marathon. Here, you need to keep going slowly. If you see the workload of the bowlers, it's a right thing to take a break, play T20, One-Dayers and then again get back to red-ball," Lad told *Sportstar*.

The switching of formats might mimic an international calendar, but for a tournament which is still, in essence, a supply line for the senior side, a sustained run in one go would arguably fetch the best performances.

Additionally, more support from the Ranji Trophy — in conditions and quality of players — at a time when the Indian team is transitioning to a new generation is a justified demand. But it is only one end of the bargain. Holding the feeder system relevant is down to the top tier, too.

Top batters after the first five rounds of matches

Name	Inn	Runs	Avg.	HS	100/50
Armaan Jaffer (Mizoram)	6	717	143.40	193	4/1
Abhinav Tejrana (Goa)	8	651	93	205	3/2
Sanat Sangwan (Delhi)	10	634	79.25	211*	2/3
Karun Nair (Karnataka)	10	602	100.33	233	2/2
R. Smaran (Karnataka)	7	595	119.00	227*	2/2

Top bowlers after the first five rounds of matches

Name	Inn	Wkts	Avg.	S/R	Best
Siddharth Desai (Gujarat)	10	35	15.34	40.47	5/61
Auqib Nabi (J&K)	9	29	13.27	31.37	7/24
Shams Mulani (Mumbai)	9	28	21.10	38.28	7/46
Mayank Mishra (Uttarakhand)	8	27	17.37	37.11	6/84
Shreyas Gopal (Karnataka)	9	27	17.51	40.55	8/110